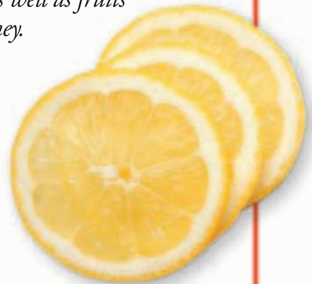
FIVE BASIC TASTES

There are more than 10,000 taste buds in your tongue. Together, they sense just five tastes—sweet, sour, salty, bitter, and umami (savory). This combination doesn't account for all the tastes you experience because your sense of smell also plays an important role in "tasting" food.

◀ SWEET *We are attracted to sweet foods because they are packed with energy. Foods tasting sweet include sugary treats, as well as fruits and honey.*

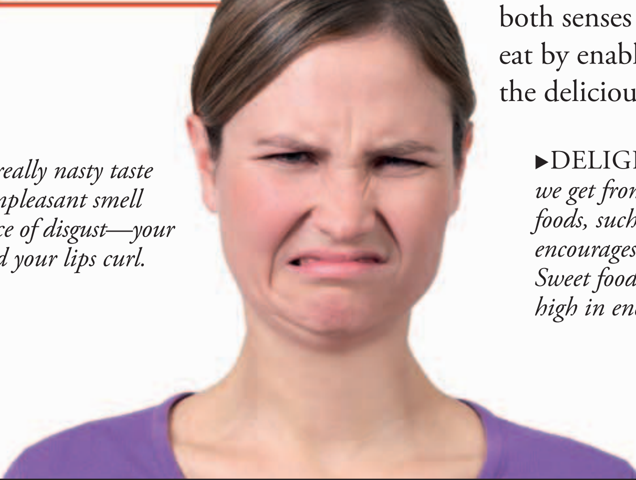


▶ SOUR *This acid taste can be so sharp that it makes the lips pucker. Sour-tasting foods include lemons and vinegar.*

◀ SALTY *Adding salt to food, such as fries, can make them more tasty. Other salty foods include soy sauce, pretzels, and bacon.*

▶ BITTER *Many children find bitter tastes unpleasant, but adults learn to enjoy bitter flavors such as coffee.*

◀ UMAMI *This mouthwatering savory or meaty taste is found in foods such as grilled meat, cheese, mushrooms, soy sauce, and seafood.*



▶DISGUST *A really nasty taste or particularly unpleasant smell produces a grimace of disgust—your nose wrinkles and your lips curl.*

SCENT SIGNALS

Our human sense of smell is far less powerful than that of many other animals. These coyote pups are using scent signals to communicate. They use smells to identify each other and mark territory. Humans also respond to scent signals, but more weakly—babies can tell their mother's scent from that of other women.

WOW!

Peppers taste "hot" because they contain capsaicin, a substance that triggers the tongue's pain detectors.

SENSING DANGER

Our senses of taste and smell help us survive by warning us about threats in two very different ways. Bitter or sour tastes warn us that foods may be poisonous to eat, and smells, such as smoke, alert us to danger. However, both senses also encourage us to eat by enabling us to experience the delicious flavors of food.

▶DELIGHT *The pleasure we get from eating sweet foods, such as ice cream, encourages us to eat more. Sweet foods are often high in energy.*